

SIPRA DAS



MENTORS INC:
NDA nurtures
regional satraps
who can sway
the mass mind

Bangalore has been reduced.

As a Modi is being followed by a Yeddy, the central leadership doesn't feel threatened. In BJP today, grassroots satraps who can sway the mass mind make it easier for the grandees in Delhi. The party president doesn't feel insecure as the leaders in the states deliver. Rajnath Singh has chosen some of the most influential regional leaders. Under his presidency, the party has won seven consecutive elections.

In any political party anywhere, it's the leader who makes the difference. Whatever be the political context, a leadership without a genuine text of change can't seize the moment. The team led by Advani and Rajnath has been reading the zeitgeist rightly. A nation under terrorist attack, soaring prices of essential commodities, collapse of urban infrastructure...the agenda of BJP has turned popular anxieties into votes. When the UPA Government celebrated its fourth anniversary, it distributed a report card that was not all that bad—and Rs 50 crore was spent on its publicity. It went kaput in the face of BJP's smart but simple slogan against the price rise.

Even as Yeddyurappa is being celebrated as Tipu Sultan redux by the

cheerleaders of the party, BJP can't afford to sit on its laurels. Except in Gujarat, its victory has not been as big as the defeat of the Congress. Storming citadels is commendable, retaining them is a bigger challenge. And the party remains starless in Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Haryana. Elsewhere, the team is socially imbalanced: backward-class leaders like Uma Bharati, Gopinath Munde and Kalyan Singh are marginalised.

PARTY IN EXTREMIS

BJP has become creative. It has the agenda, the idea and the right attitude. What does the Congress have? A leader who overwhelms the party but not the country. Sonia Gandhi, in the fantasy of the desperate Congressmen, is still Our Lady of Deliverance. She has not let regional leaders grow: there are no answers to Yeddyurappa or Modi in a party that was once home to such legends like K. Kamaraj and Kamalapati Tripathi. The original Mrs G could have won India without regional leaders and yet, she allowed them to flourish. Sonia is not yet Mrs G, even after 10 long years of rehearsal. The entire Congress solar system

revolves around 10 Janpath. The question that will never be asked within the party is: can the centre hold?

Later this year, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Chattisgarh and probably Jharkhand will go to the polls, but the Congress has no alternatives to Shivraj Singh Chauhan, Raman Singh and Vasundhara Raje. Leaders like Ashok Gehlot (Rajasthan) and Digvijay Singh (Madhya Pradesh) have been condemned to clerical indignities at the headquarters. Most glaringly, the Congress is too paranoid to project a prime ministerial candidate even as Advani is hardselling himself, hopping from book launches to election rallies with remarkable agility. With 10 chief ministers as his regional commanders, Advani is going to be a formidable foe. Rahul Gandhi, the heir apparent who has been braving the dust and heat of the hinterland, doesn't seem to have discovered India yet—or his own voice as a Gandhi-in-waiting.

The Congress doesn't seem to have a face or a voice that can galvanise, that too despite the fact that the UPA Government has quite a few achievements to brag about, nuclear deal or not. But who is there to brag? Certainly not the prime minister, and the gentle-

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